Rajiv had 'overplayed his hand ... and India punched above its weight ... in the end neither the Soviet Union nor, especially, the US, valued its relationship with India above their respective regional and global priorities'.[115] Rajiv's failure to ensure India's role in Afghanistan—and presence at Geneva—unleashed a storm in the Indian parliament. By late 1987, Rajiv's conciliatory approach had evolved into a highly aggressive policy stance, most visible in Sri Lanka and Pakistan, but also, in theory if not in practice, towards Afghanistan.

Could Kabul be genuinely non-aligned, as India wanted, in light of India's own tilt towards Moscow and Pakistan's alliance with Washington? Not according to the Pentagon, and neither according to the Kremlin. New Delhi's pro-Soviet leanings had made India's grand strategy obsolete. As a *Times of India* editorial argued in March 1988, 'since India has had close relations with the Kabul regime and none at all with the rebel groups throughout the Soviet-occupation of that country, any last-minute attempt to project itself as a mediator could only be counter-productive'.[116] Most US officials, including Reagan, remained unconvinced (and unimpressed) by Indian's platitudes on non-alignment. Rajiv's advocacy of a coalition government in Kabul effectively meant a compromise between the Soviet Union and the US on one hand, India and Pakistan on the other, and the Kabul government and its adversaries on top of it. Such a solution went against the grain of the global Cold War politics. Despite the wisdom of India's stance, Washington was more concerned about defeating the Soviets than worrying about the potentially negative impact of supporting Afghan Islamists. In 1988, the US Congress agreed to offer another six-year aid package to Pakistan, similar to the US$ 3.2 billion deal it had offered to Rawalpindi in 1981. The amount was increased to US$ 4 billion this time.[117]

Kabul durbar

Even if one assumes that the two world powers would have reached an agreement on Afghanistan, would the situation on the ground in Afghanistan have allowed for a negotiated settlement? Not really. With the presidential palace at its center and communists at helm, Kabul was a city of intrigue in the 1980s. A space of political arbitration; its political leaders were known to be astute and ruthless.